

## Where Have We Come From and Where Are We Going?

- *after Brian Doyle's "Joyas Voladoras"*

Consider the Milky Way for a long moment. The Milky Way is 100,000 light-years across. The Milky Way could fit  $6.7 \times 1,039$  Earths. The Milky Way houses at least 100 billion celestial bodies and is only 1 percent of our largest universe. We as humans are infinitesimal compared to the impossibly vast size of our solar system, and even further, our universe. The Milky Way is 13.6 billion years old. The Milky Way moves at 1.3 million miles an hour. It was born from a handful of elements that happened to mix just right and in turn, life crawled from the resulting boiling primordial soup 3.7 billion years ago. We happened upon life how a child happens upon a tarnished penny wedged within the crack of a sidewalk.

Our Earth was comprised entirely of molten magma in its early days. It survived a collision with a small planet that created our Moon. It has stood resilient to 5 mass extinctions. It has sustained creation through 4 eons. Through all of our technological advancements, we've yet to find another planet that comes close to the perfect conditions of Earth to prove the existence of other life. And though there are planets that are cruel to their atmospheres, nothing compares to the harsh environment we have braved. Consider for a moment the creatures who did not open their eyes again today, this very day, on the Earth: children caught outside by a supercell, mothers, a grizzly bear from the frigid tundra, brothers left in the woods in a mudslide, your

neighbor's dog, the cat across the street that you started feeding last week, the 52-hertz whale by killer whales—its own kind, only by name—Tom Cruise, Vermin Supreme (the man who ran for office with a boot atop his noggin), the Earth itself in just 5 billion years—each the most amazing thing you have never seen. Each one victim to themselves, Earth's will, and the Sun; each crafted from the same atoms. Each snuffed by the same broth.

Now, the universe of just perfect conditions suffocating us like a wet blanket still has the capacity for mystery. Consider for a long moment the ever-elusive Planet Nine. Planet Nine theoretically exists 400 astronomical units away. Planet Nine is theorized to take 20,000 years of our time to orbit the Sun. Planet Nine is assumed to be a gaseous planet amassing 5 to 10 times greater than the size of Earth. Planet Nine's existence is thought to be proven through clustering and perpendicular orbits, close proximity of Neptune-esque bodies to the Sun, mathematical equations, and theories of physics. And yet, physical proof of the planet has yet to be produced. A whole planet, possibly quintuple the size of ours, floating in the darkness like a translucent fleck of dust—proven only to be actual when glanced upon by a direct sunray, a reality only known by the planet itself. Maybe it's an entire civilization, a futuristic utopia filled with flying cars, gold cities, and a healthy planet. Maybe it's a deserted anthill, its previous inhabitants up and gone, dried and desiccated living rooms on display to interstellar travelers. Maybe, that's what we will be when we are engulfed by our Sun. Maybe, that's what will become of Earth

once the solar flares and flooding oceans cause our extinction. No solid proof, no hard evidence. Only a few math equations and scientific principles to suggest a *possibility*.

There is a 1 in 60 billion chance to exist as life on a hospitable planet. Past that roadblock, you have a one in FOUR TRILLION chance of being conceived as you. We were never meant to be here, and yet, here you are. Against all odds. You can tell yourself that there's no point in being here, that we'll be swallowed up by our Sun if we don't kill our climate first. You'd be right. But you feel it, sometimes, don't you? You feel why it matters when you hear the squeak of a vinyl booth at a diner and know in a second all of the people who have sat there before you, when you hear your father's favorite song on the radio years after he's passed, when that same tabby cat mews on your doorstep, You feel it in the way your dog's tail spins round and round when you walk through the door and when you break bread around the dinner table with your loved ones under flickering candlelight. You feel it in the air after a storm, when the ground is broken with the release of Mother Earth and settles between your toes as you watch the birds your grandmother took care of flit about in the trees, the way the water sparkles when the Sun breaks over the horizon in the early hours of the morning and how your mom calls that a "glimmer moment." You feel it all around you—there's never a time you don't. How could you not? It will follow you until you understand and then it will linger to remind you every day. Every person, every moment, every meal, every loss. It all matters, because we *were never*

*meant to be here.*

Maybe, we are only letter-shaped pasta floating amongst others in chicken broth, spelling gibberish to whoever views it. Maybe, Planet Nine was once a great utopia of hyper-technology and cyber-humanity turned ghost-planet, turned mass-of-absence. Maybe, Earth is a terrarium in a third-grade classroom with grime smudged across the glass as onlookers press their snotty faces and grubby hands against it to get a better look at what's within. Maybe, the Milky Way is a sandcastle molded by a red plastic bucket in a larger sandbox, its brick facade crumbling from age, moss growing upon the gargoyles of time. Maybe, it's whatever we make of it.